

STATE REVIEW LEARNINGS:

SOUTHERN ARKANSAS

UNIVERSITY

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

On-Site Review: April 3-4, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

The report uses evidence from state data collection and an onsite review to examine educator preparation program performance. The information in this report is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

This report rates the EPP on all three Standards of the Arkansas Education Preparation Provider State Review Framework, which are fundamental to support teacher candidates in their journey to becoming successful teachers who meet the needs of students in Arkansas:

- Standard 1, "Candidate Recruitment and Completion," is rated primarily with quantitative data from state data collection.
- For Standard 2, "Preparing Candidates Effectively," criteria to assess performance results from document review, observations, and focus group conversations with stakeholders, including teacher preparation program deans, candidates, current school leaders and teachers, faculty, and the DESE staff.
- The ratings for Standard 3, "Supporting Workforce Needs," are based on state data reporting.

Performance Levels are defined as follows:

Performance Level	Average Score Equivalent
EXCEEDS	Average score equivalent to exceeds on two of three standards or indicators
MEETS	Average score equivalent to meets on all three standards or indicators
APPROACHING	Average score equivalent to approaching on one standard or indicator and meets on the other two

BELOW	Average score equivalent to below on one standard or indicator and approaching on the other two
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SOUTHERN ARKANSAS UNIVERSITY

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

Overall Performance Level		
MEETS		
Performance Levels by Standard		
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion	Standard 2: Preparing Candidates Effectively	Standard 3: Supporting Workforce Needs
MEETS	MEETS	METS

STANDARD 1: RECRUITMENT & COMPLETION

Standard 1 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 1.1 Plans	Indicator 1.2 Recruitment	Indicator 1.3 Completion
MEETS	MEETS	EXCEEDS
Recommendations		
Begin preparing to submit a formal plan in October that addresses all Indicators in the State Review Framework and provides evidence of action towards continuous improvement. <i>(Focus Area: Criteria 1.1a)</i>		

INDICATOR 1.1: PLANS

Criteria 1.1a: Programs have formal plans to meet the targets described in the state review framework (i.e., Standards 1-3) and show evidence of acting on their plans	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	EPPs were not asked to submit formal plans to meet the state review framework targets or to show evidence of acting on their plans as part of the Spring 2024 review cycle. As a result, all EPPs in this cycle will receive a rating of MEETS.

INDICATOR 1.2: RECRUITMENT

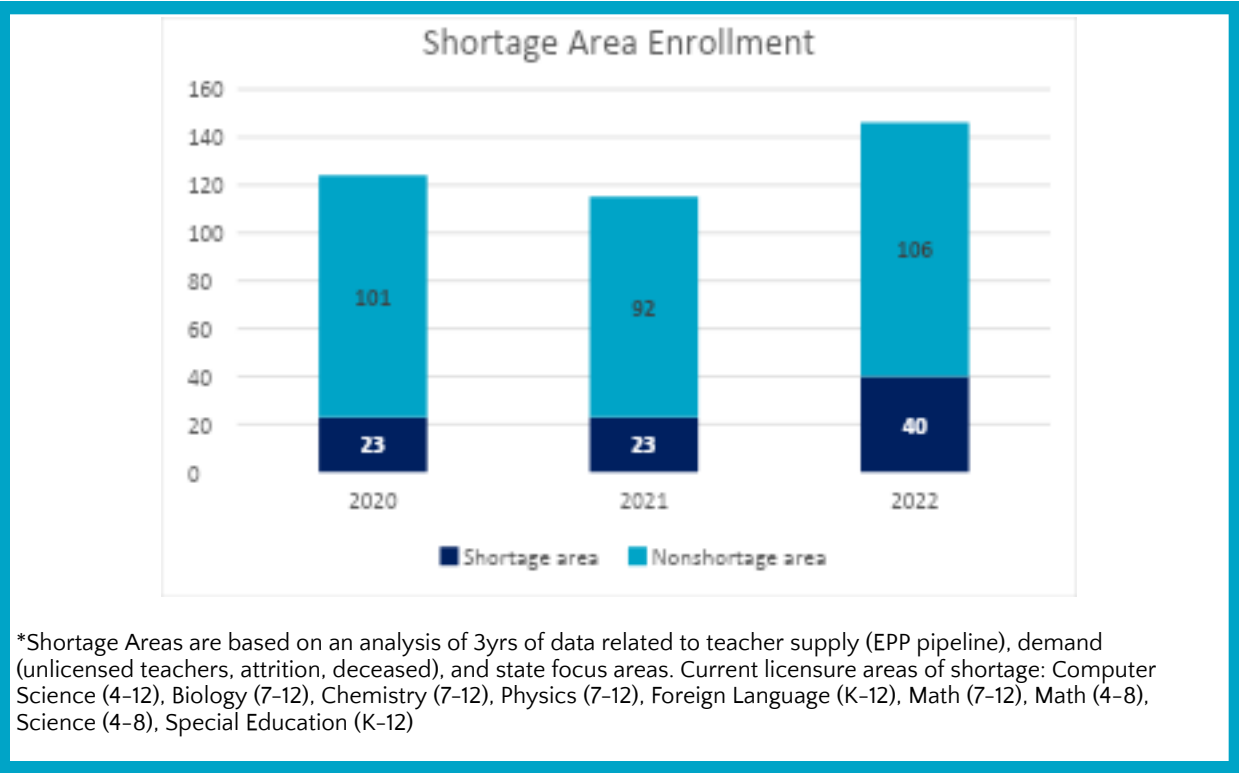
Criteria 1.2a: Programs meet annual recruitment targets that align with their program size and Arkansas's workforce needs			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Growth in 3yr Average Enrollment	Performance Level
Percentage growth in 3yr average enrollment	10%	153.8%	EXCEEDS

Metric is the percentage growth between blue and green boxes.

Year	Percentage Growth
2017	35
2018	72
2019	39
2020	116
2021	114
2022	138

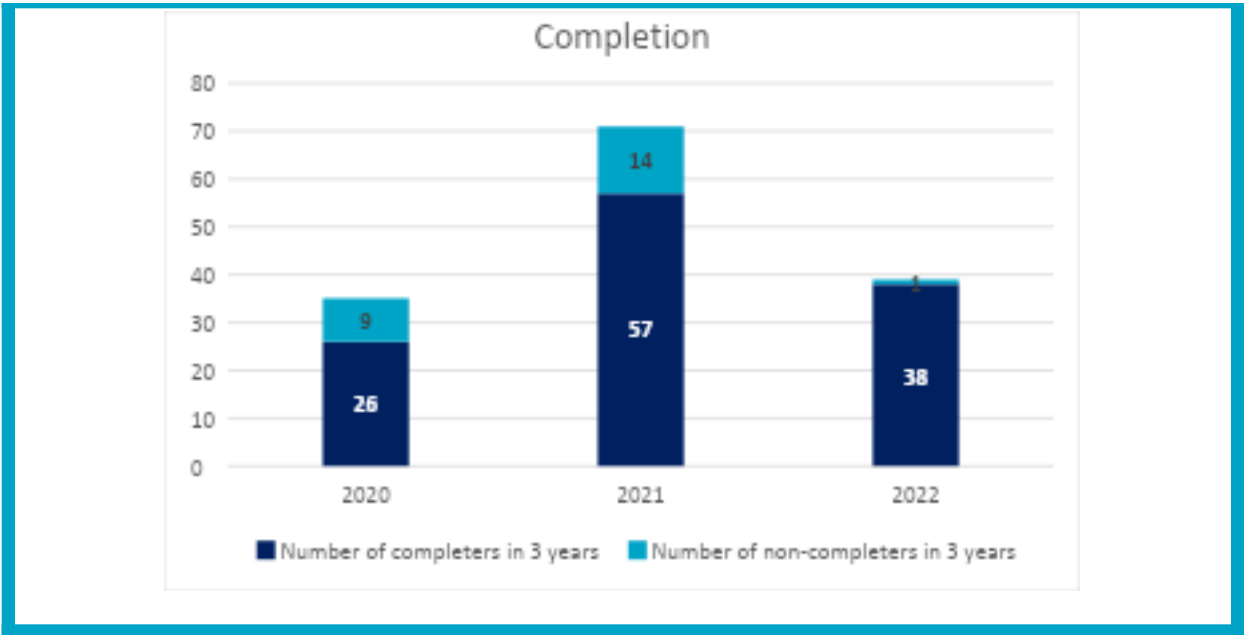
*The enrollment growth target was established to close the sizeable gap between EPP completers and those leaving the classroom over the next 10yrs. EPPs can earn a “Meets” rating by demonstrating positive program enrollment growth (i.e., growth greater than zero) and an “Exceeds” rating by demonstrating growth greater than 10 percent.

Criteria 1.2b: Programs recruit candidates for Arkansas certification shortage areas in proportion to the need			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percent of New Enrollees in Shortage Areas	Performance Level
Percentage of program candidates recruited in shortage areas	24%	22%	MEETS



INDICATOR 1.3: COMPLETION

Criteria 1.3a: Candidates have high rates of completion			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Completion Rate	Performance Level
Three-year average completion rate	75%	83%	EXCEEDS



Standard 2: PREPARING CANDIDATES EFFECTIVELY

Standard 2 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 2.1 Coursework	Indicator 2.2 Clinical Experiences	Indicator 2.3 Development
MEETS	MEETS	MEETS
Recommendations		
The alternative program at Southern Arkansas University provided evidence to highlight their commitment to using data to develop their coursework, design their clinical internship and support teacher candidates. SAU regularly surveys course instructors, clinical supervisors, mentor teachers and teacher candidates to better understand what is working well and where to continue to improve. Course instructors and clinical supervisors are a strength at SAU, providing candidates with support and feedback. Recommendations to strengthen candidate preparation includes: • Document a clear and intentional process to fully support graduate students in their internship experience which includes opportunities to expose them to a variety of experiences especially for those candidates already in a teacher of record role. Build and maintain strong relationships with schools where teacher candidates work that may be outside the current list of partner districts. (Focus Areas: Criteria 2.2a Metric 2, 2.2c Metric 1) • Document a clear and intentional system to recognize high performing teacher candidates and offer opportunities and feedback that encourage their retention; this may be in collaboration with partner school leaders and/or mentor teachers. (Focus Area: Criteria 2.3b Metric 4) • Begin preparing now to meet the state's one-year residency requirement that will apply to spring 2027 completers and beyond. Formalize systems and structures to ensure that the mentor teachers and clinical supervisors working with candidates in the building are experienced, very effective and, by the 2026-2027 school year, have received DESE-recognized coaching training. (Focus Area: Criteria 2.2b, 2.3c Metric 2)		

INDICATOR 2.1: COURSEWORK

Criteria 2.1a: Candidates receive high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based
MEETS
Metric 1: Incorporation and demonstration of best practices around content instruction
MEETS
Coursework clearly and intentionally incorporates nationally recognized best practices around content instruction. Reviewers observed HQIM, such as Core Knowledge Language Arts (CKLA), Illustrative Math, and Eureka Math, and

best practices, such as unpacking standards and aligning standards across coursework to lessons, objectives, and assessments.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas K-12 Standards in coursework as a foundation for teacher development

MEETS

Coursework clearly and intentionally familiarizes candidates with Arkansas K-12 Standards throughout all grade bands within the licensure area. In the Coursework Focus group, participants shared that their lessons are tied back to standards, explaining they had to take standards and map them back to the state standards to understand the various parts, what is important, and how to prioritize them. Participants also gave specific examples of how they are expected to map standards across grade levels to plan vertically.

Science of Reading (SOR) courses, MAT 5003 and MAT 6083, align with DESE-approved requirements.

Criteria 2.1b: Candidates' coursework supports their development as a teacher

MEETS

Metric 1: Sequence and progression of courses

MEETS

Courses are clearly and intentionally sequenced across programs of study to build off previous coursework, providing candidates with an opportunity to show proficiency. Reviewers observed a progressive increase in rigor in Literacy 1 and Literacy 2 courses, noting they followed a coherent path. In the alternative program, Assessment is one of the first courses candidates take so that it lays the foundation for future courses. In the Coursework focus group, participants shared more about the pre-observation, observation, and post-observation (POP) cycles, which include reinforcement opportunities and opportunities to reflect and receive feedback.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas Educator Competencies and Arkansas Teaching Standards in coursework

MEETS

Coursework clearly and intentionally incorporates Arkansas Teaching Standards in a way that develops candidates to meet the knowledge and skills of their required licensure areas. Courses are aligned with the Arkansas Teaching Standards as evidenced in syllabi. In the Coursework focus group, one participant shared the example of professional responsibility, one of the standards, and how it is emphasized at SAU. "I always need to be engaged and interacting, it's [the program] preparing you to be in that classroom and be the teacher."

Metric 3: Alignment of coursework to clinical experience

EXCEEDS

Coursework is clearly and intentionally aligned to clinical experience, and candidates consistently have opportunities to reflect on and articulate the alignment with their clinical supervisor and course instructors. SAU earns an exceeding rating for this indicator due to annual evaluation and continuous improvement. In the Coursework focus group, one participant stated, "What we are given in our coursework and our experiences in coursework go hand-in-hand with what we see in our residency." Reviewers also noted that in the Teaching Literacy I, Teaching Literacy II & Classroom Assessment (MAT 5173) course observations, the coursework required students to create and teach a lesson and then reflect and analyze it. Course instructors shared that data from the POP cycle is used to collect data about the clinical experience, inform coursework and class discussions, and identify where programmatic changes are needed.

Criteria 2.1c: Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors

MEETS

Metric 1: Quality of course instructors

MEETS

Most course instructors show deep knowledge of Arkansas K-12 Standards, content knowledge, and content pedagogy, as evidenced through their training, work experience, education, and collaborative PLCs. Course instructors will also attend district training to learn district-specific HQIM.

Metric 2: Effectiveness of course instructors

MEETS

Most course instructors have a proven history and/or show evidence of strong coursework facilitation and feedback and support. All participants in the Coursework focus group agreed they receive a lot of high-quality feedback to improve their coursework and field experiences. Peer and student evaluations also indicate that course instructors are effective.

INDICATOR 2.2: CLINICAL EXPERIENCES

Criteria 2.2a: Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as a teacher

APPROACHING

Metric 1: The sequence of clinical experiences

MEETS

The overall sequence of clinical experiences clearly and intentionally builds off previous experiences and includes opportunities for learning and development. In the alternative program, all teacher candidates must complete 24 hours of practice-based coursework before entering their full-year residency.

Metric 2: The variety of clinical experiences

APPROACHING

The overall variety of clinical experiences provides some opportunities for candidates to work with students with varied learning needs. Program Directors noted that alternative route teachers come to the program from many entrance points – some are current teachers of record, while others have never taught before. Those who are currently teachers of record may not have an opportunity to work across multiple grade levels or in various settings. In contrast, some teachers who are placed in an internship position may have more varied experiences.

Criteria 2.2b: Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship

MEETS

Metric 1: The effectiveness of Experienced Mentor Teachers

MEETS

Most experienced mentor teachers are equipped and demonstrate that they have the coaching skills to properly support and develop a candidate's pedagogical development. SAU maintains a "Mentor Teacher Tracker" that includes data regarding a mentor teacher's fit for the role, perception survey results, and whether they should be recommended for the future. Evidence from the perception survey shows that most mentor teachers are a good match and are recommended for future SAU teacher candidates.

Note: By 2026–2027, evidence that experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents have received DESE-recognized coaching training must be shown to meet this metric.

Metric 2: Quality of selection process for experienced mentor teachers

EXCEEDS

A clear and intentional process is in place to select experienced mentor teachers based on criteria that may include years of classroom experience, demonstrated instructional effectiveness, depth of content, and pedagogical knowledge. If an alternative route teacher candidate works in a school outside of an established partnership, SAU and the district/school sign an MOU that outlines the expectations regarding a mentor teacher. This includes the request to "Assign a highly qualified mentor to the teacher candidate preferably in the same grade level and content area." In addition to selection criteria, SAU maintains the "Mentor Teacher Tracker," facilitates a perception survey about mentor teacher effectiveness, and uses this data to continually improve the experienced mentor teacher selection process.

Note: By 2026–2027, evidence that experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents have a minimum 3 years teaching experience, hold a standard Arkansas educators license with a Lead or Master Professional Educator designation, and have evidence of an annual rating of effective or higher in DESE's Educator Effectiveness System must be shown to meet this metric.

Metric 3: Quality of clinical supervisors

EXCEEDS

Most program clinical supervisors show evidence of effective instructional practices and coaching with a positive impact. Reviewers observed strong coaching and feedback in the coaching observations, highlighting teacher strengths and reinforcing growth areas. An alternative route teacher in the Clinical Experience focus group explained they submit a mini lesson to their supervisor each month and receive coaching and feedback (both oral and written). All Clinical Supervisors are trained in Cognitive Coaching or NIET and HQIM. All supervisors are part of Professional Learning Communities (PLCs) to develop coaching and calibrate how they support teacher candidates. Additionally, evidence shows SAU has a comprehensive evaluation system that includes candidate perceptions, peer evaluations, and supervisor evaluations to support the effectiveness of clinical supervisors. They also have a system to measure and track supervisor quality and effectiveness.

Metric 4: Quality of feedback to candidates

MEETS

Candidates consistently receive high-quality feedback from their experienced mentor teachers and/or clinical supervisor, which is frequent, written, oral, connected to the TESS rubric, clearly linked to evidence of student learning during observed lessons, and built on the previous feedback. The POP cycles include formal opportunities for feedback and include pre- and post-conferences. In the Experienced Mentor Teaching focus group, one participant shared there is a Google form they use to give instant feedback, and they are available to help with lesson plans and meet on Zoom when needed to provide additional feedback and support.

Note: By 2024-25, evidence that the Aspiring Teacher Rubric is in use by EPPs must be shown to meet this metric.

Criteria 2.2c: Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that facilitate the development of strong candidates

APPROACHING

Metric 1: Quality of partnership with districts/schools

APPROACHING

Collaborative processes are in place with some districts/schools to co-construct the clinical internship for candidates. Teaching candidates in the alternative program can be hired as a teacher of record for their year-long internship or placed into an internship with a partner school. If the teacher is hired by a district that is not a current school partner, there is a clear MOU that sets expectations for the partnership and describes the support that the school must offer. However, in the evidence gathered, it is unclear how much collaboration exists between SAU and schools outside of their established partnerships and how much clinical supervisors and mentor teachers at those schools collaborate.

Metric 2: Support and development for clinical supervisors

MEETS

Collaborative processes are consistently in place to support and develop effective clinical supervisors. Clinical supervisors attend monthly trainings and participate in conferences to continually develop and calibrate in their role and how they support residents. Half of the Clinical Supervisors receive Cognitive Coaching, while the other half receive NIET coaching. In addition to formal conferences and training, Clinical Supervisors share that they receive support from their Department Chair and MAT Director.

INDICATOR 2.3: DEVELOPMENT

Criteria 2.3a: Candidates are successful with their program coursework

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate proficiency in coursework

MEETS

Most candidates show proficiency in coursework requirements. SAU provided evidence regarding teacher candidate GPA that shows, upon admittance, the average GPA was 3.4, and the exit GPA was 3.7, indicating that teacher candidates are successful in their coursework.

Metric 2: Quality of candidate support across coursework

MEETS

Candidates are consistently provided with an individualized support plan if their coursework requirements are not on track, and they take an active role in creating the plan and monitoring progress. The "Professional Competences Alert Process" outlines a clear process to support a candidate if they are off track. This process includes meetings with faculty, advisors, and the candidate and clear steps to resolve the issue. SAU maintains a "Tracker of Alerts and Milestones Expectations" to consistently support off-track candidates, including clear next steps and follow-up notes.

Criteria 2.3b: Candidates are successful in their clinical internship

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate attainment of clinical internship goals and milestones

MEETS

SAU has a set of clear and appropriate goals and milestones for candidates' clinical internships, and most candidates meet their clinical experience goals and milestones. Data provided by SAU shows TESS ratings from formal observations for the alternative candidates during Internships I and II. The evidence shows a 3-year trend of over 90% of all alternative candidates scoring "Effective" on all 4 TESS Domains.

Metric 2: Candidate impact on student growth

MEETS

The evidence provided shows that candidates have the capacity to impact student growth. In addition to the strong TESS ratings, reviewers observed impact on student growth through their coaching observation with pre- and post-lesson assessments. Clinical Supervisors also shared that teacher candidates are taught to "design coherent instruction," which includes pre-assessments, analyzing student data, and self-reflecting on the data to differentiate instruction. This process is part of the POP cycle feedback. All alternative route teacher candidates are involved in their district's PLC process, which also helps them learn from veteran teachers to improve.

Metric 3: Candidate proficiency in effective teaching skills

MEETS

Evidence demonstrates most candidates receive a score of 'Effective' on the TESS framework at the end of their clinical internship. The most recent academic year indicates that over 90% of all alternative candidates scored 'Effective' in all TESS components at Milestones 2 and 3, demonstrating candidate effectiveness.

Note: By 2024-25, evidence that the Aspiring Teacher Rubric is in use by EPPs must be shown to meet this metric.

Metric 4: Quality of candidate support across clinical internship

APPROACHING

All candidates with varied needs are provided the support they need, including individualized support plans. All teacher candidates are observed throughout their internship, and a database is maintained to track progress and flag if a teacher candidate needs additional support. The Quality Assurance Coordinator receives an automatic alert whenever a candidate's scores are submitted to the system and do not meet benchmarks. At that point, the "Milestone Expectations Process" begins. The program monitors assessment scores in real-time to ensure candidates not on track in their clinical experiences receive the individualized support plans necessary to improve their practice.

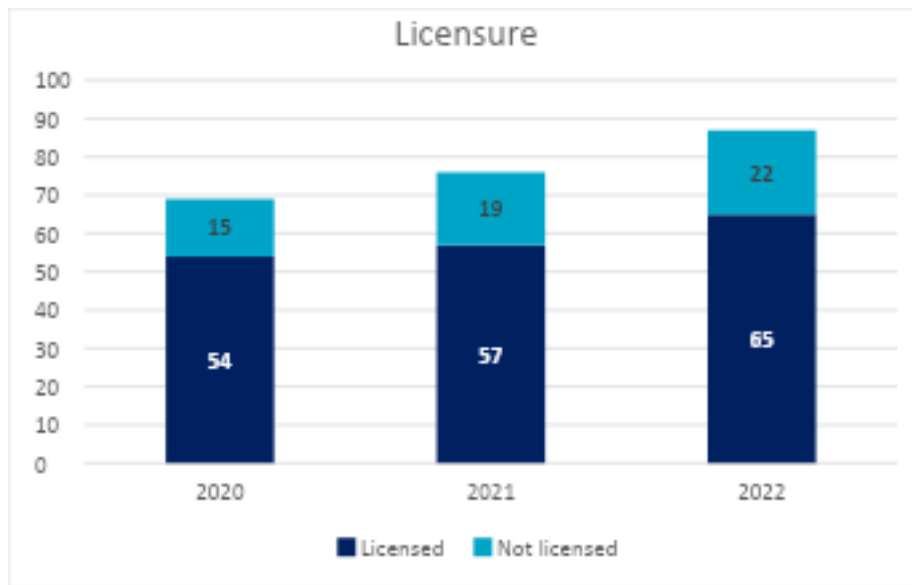
No evidence was observed or submitted regarding feedback and opportunities given to high-performing alternative teacher candidates to encourage retention.

STANDARD 3: SUPPORTING WORKFORCE NEEDS

Standard 3 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 3.1 Licensure	Indicator 3.2 Employment	Indicator 3.3 Effectiveness
APPROACHING	EXCEEDS	EXCEEDS
Recommendations		
SAU's alternative program exceeds nearly all of the State's targets for EPPs to support Arkansas's workforce needs, including completers who become licensed, work in Arkansas public schools and districts (including priority districts and subjects), and stay in the classroom for multiple years. EPP Supervisors and Completers feel that SAU prepares candidates well to be teachers. Recommendations include: Establish programmatic support to ensure that alternative program completers are prepared to obtain standard licensure. (<i>Focus Area: Criteria 3.1a</i>)		

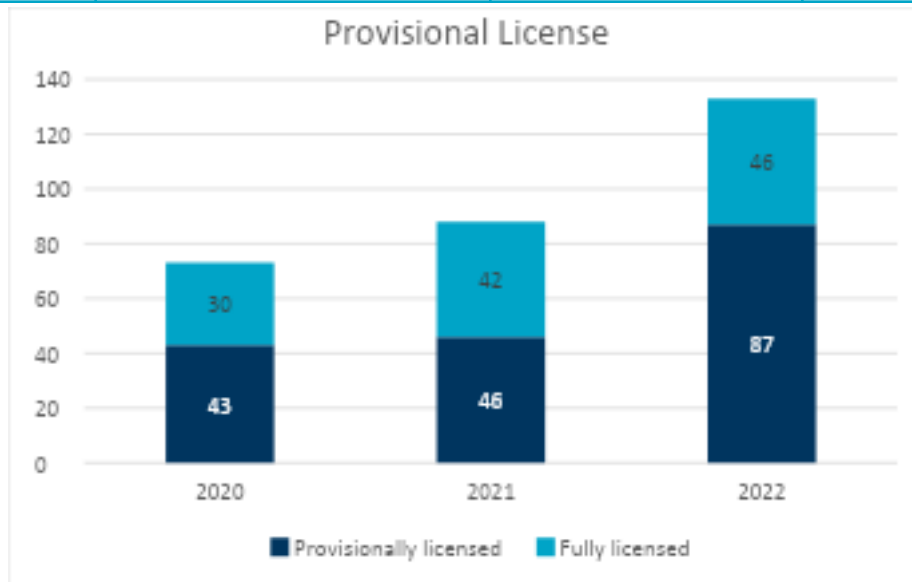
INDICATOR 3.1: LICENSURE

Criteria 3.1a: A high proportion of program candidates obtain a standard license			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who have earned a standard license within one year of completion	76%	76%	MEETS



Criteria 3.1b: A high proportion of alternative route enrollees are provisionally licensed

Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of employed alternative route enrollees who are provisionally licensed	69%	59.9%	APPROACHING



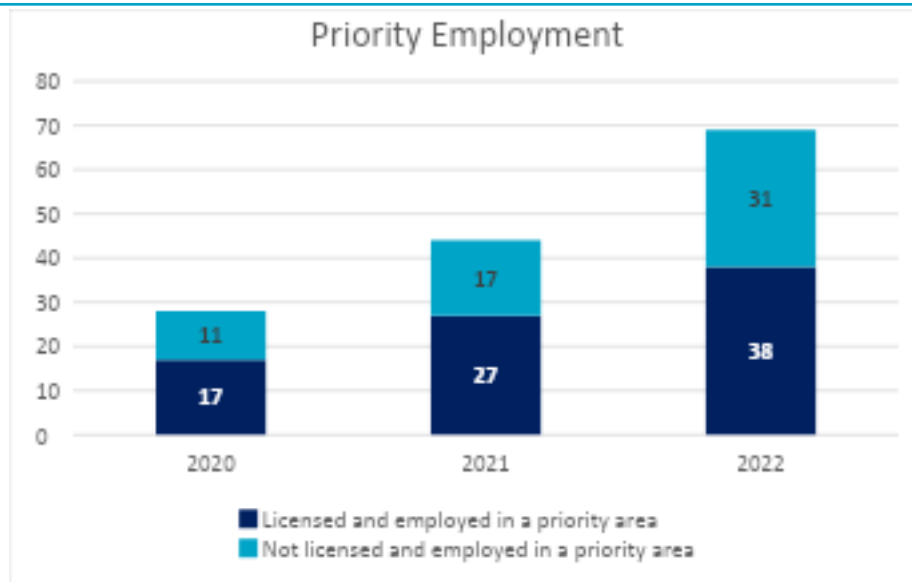
Criteria 3.1c: A high proportion of traditional program candidates pass the content exam in their area on the first try

Metric	Target	EPP's First-Time Pass Percentage	Performance Level
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Percentage of first-time licensure exam test takers that pass on their first try	n/a	n/a	n/a
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INDICATOR 3.2: EMPLOYMENT

Criteria 3.2a: A high proportion of completers are employed in Arkansas public schools															
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed	Performance Level												
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in Arkansas public schools in their first three years after completion	64%	81.6%	EXCEEDS												
Employment <table><thead><tr><th>Year</th><th>Licensed and employed</th><th>Not licensed and employed</th></tr></thead><tbody><tr><td>2020</td><td>23</td><td>5</td></tr><tr><td>2021</td><td>36</td><td>8</td></tr><tr><td>2022</td><td>56</td><td>13</td></tr></tbody></table>				Year	Licensed and employed	Not licensed and employed	2020	23	5	2021	36	8	2022	56	13
Year	Licensed and employed	Not licensed and employed													
2020	23	5													
2021	36	8													
2022	56	13													
Criteria 3.2b: A high proportion of completers work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects															
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed Priority	Performance Level												
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects in their first three years after completion	40%	58.2%	EXCEEDS												



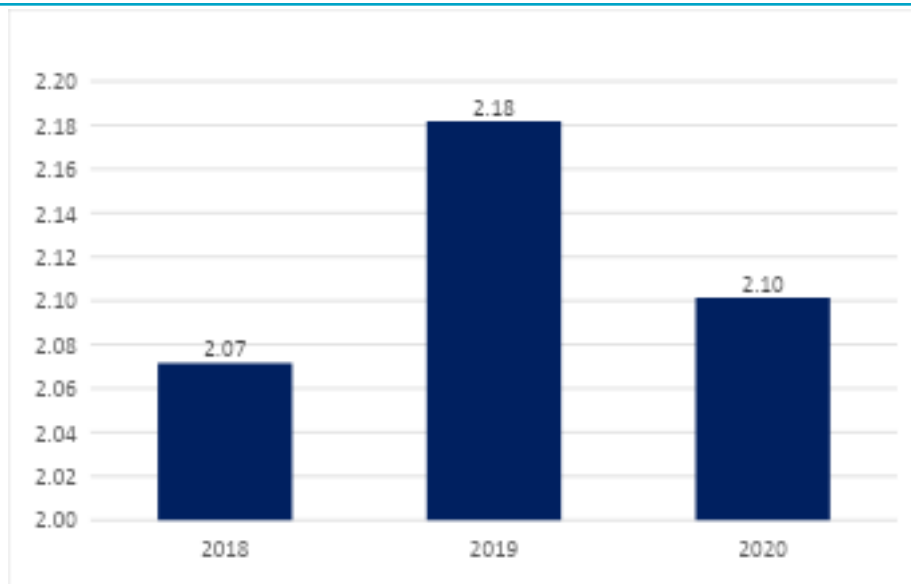
*Priority Employment is employment in a high-need subject area and/or geographical shortage area. Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline), demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased), and state focus areas.

Current subject shortage areas for employment: Computer Science, Secondary Science, Foreign Language, Secondary Math, Middle School Math, Middle School Science, and Special Education.

Current geographical shortage areas are school districts located in the following co-op regions: Arkansas River ESC, Great Rivers ESC, Pulaski Co Schools, Southeast AR ESC.

Criteria 3.2c: Program completers remain in the classroom for multiple years

Metric	Target	EPP's Average Years of Experience, 3 Years After Completion	Performance Level
Program completers' average licensed teaching experience in Arkansas's public schools 3 years after completion	1.7	2.12	EXCEEDS



INDICATOR 3.3: EFFECTIVENESS

Criteria 3.3a: School leaders rate program completers that they hire as effective classroom teachers			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
School leaders' perception of program completer effectiveness based on responses to the EPP Completer Supervisor Survey conducted annually by DESE	81%	96.6%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3b: Completers feel that their program prepared them well to be a teacher			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
Program completers' perception of how well their program prepared them to be a teacher based on responses to the EPP Completer Survey conducted annually by DESE	75%	85.7%	EXCEEDS
Criteria 3.3c: A high proportion of program completers have above-average value-added scores			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage with Average Value-Added of 80+	Performance Level
Percentage of program completers who have above-average value-added scores in their first three years after completion	43%	49%	EXCEEDS

